Empowerment with English

A course reader

Chennai Mathematical Institute

Autumn 2026

About this edition. Texts reset from the handouts posted on Moodle, weeks 1 to 11. Scanned readings were transcribed by OCR and checked by hand, and obvious typos in the handouts were corrected. The original Moodle files remain the reference. Week 4 had no readings posted. Line numbers in the poems are counted every fifth line from the first line.

Contents

Week 1 *The Sonnet*

Sonnet 65 *William Shakespeare* 2
Ozymandias *Percy Bysshe Shelley* 3
The Word of the Silence *Sri Aurobindo* 4

Week 2 *Phonetics & the Short Story*

Phonetic Symbols *Reference chart* 6
An Astrologer's Day *R. K. Narayan* 7

Week 3 *Drama*

The Merchant of Venice: a summary *Course handout* 13
The Merchant of Venice, Act IV, Scene i *William Shakespeare* 15

Week 5 *The Short Story & Biography*

The Refugee *Pearl S. Buck* 39
Srinivasa Ramanujan *C. P. Snow* 45

Week 6 *The Dramatic Monologue*

Ulysses *Alfred, Lord Tennyson* 52

Week 7 *The Dramatic Monologue*

My Last Duchess *Robert Browning* 56

Week 8 *The Short Story*

The Verger *W. Somerset Maugham* 60

Week 9 *Biography*

Stanley Finds Livingstone *Lawrence Wilson* 69

Week 10 *The Ballad*

The Ballad of Father Gilligan *William Butler Yeats* 78
The Rime of the Ancient Mariner, Part I *Samuel Taylor Coleridge* 80

Week 11 *Idioms*

English Idioms *Course handout* 85

Week one

The Sonnet

4–10 August

Sonnet 65

William Shakespeare

Since brass, nor stone, nor earth, nor boundless sea
But sad mortality o'er-sways their power,
How with this rage shall beauty hold a plea,
Whose action is no stronger than a flower?
O, how shall summer's honey breath hold out
Against the wreckful siege of batt'ring days,
When rocks impregnable are not so stout,
Nor gates of steel so strong, but time decays?
O fearful meditation! Where, alack,
Shall time's best jewel from time's chest lie hid?
Or what strong hand can hold his swift foot back?
Or who his spoil of beauty can forbid?
O, none, unless this miracle have might,
That in black ink my love may still shine bright.

Ozymandias

Percy Bysshe Shelley

I met a traveller from an antique land
Who said: Two vast and trunkless legs of stone
Stand in the desert. Near them, on the sand,
Half sunk, a shattered visage lies, whose frown,
And wrinkled lip, and sneer of cold command,
Tell that its sculptor well those passions read
Which yet survive, stamped on these lifeless things,
The hand that mocked them and the heart that fed:
And on the pedestal these words appear:
"My name is Ozymandias, king of kings:
Look on my works, ye Mighty, and despair!"
Nothing beside remains. Round the decay
Of that colossal wreck, boundless and bare
The lone and level sands stretch far away.

The Word of the Silence

Sri Aurobindo

A bare impersonal hush is now my mind,
A world of sight clear and inimitable,
A volume of silence by a Godhead signed,
A greatness pure of thought, virgin of will.

Once on its pages Ignorance could write
In a scribble of intellect the blind guess of Time
And cast gleam-messages of ephemeral light,
A food for souls that wander on Nature's rim.

But now I listen to a greater Word
Born from the mute unseen omniscient Ray:
The Voice that only Silence' ear has heard
Leaps missioned from an eternal glory of Day.

All turns from a wideness and unbroken peace
To a tumult of joy in a sea of wide release.

Week two

Phonetics & the Short Story

11–17 August

Phonetic Symbols

Reference chart

Consonants

1	/p/	pen	/pen/
2	/b/	big	/bɪg/
3	/t/	tea	/tiː/
4	/d/	do	/duː/
5	/k/	cat	/kæt/
6	/g/	go	/gəʊ/
7	/f/	four	/fɔː/
8	/v/	very	/'veri/
9	/s/	son	/sʌn/
10	/z/	zoo	/zuː/
11	/l/	live	/lɪv/
12	/m/	my	/maɪ/
13	/n/	near	/nɪə/
14	/h/	happy	/'hæpi/
15	/r/	red	/red/
16	/j/	yes	/jes/
17	/w/	want	/wɒnt/
18	/θ/	thanks	/θæŋks/
19	/ð/	the	/ðə/
20	/ʃ/	she	/ʃiː/
21	/ʒ/	television	/'telɪvɪʒn/
22	/tʃ/	child	/tʃaɪld/
23	/dʒ/	German	/'dʒɜːmən/
24	/ŋ/	English	/'ɪŋglɪʃ/

Vowels

25	/iː/	see	/siː/
26	/ɪ/	his	/hɪz/
27	/i/	twenty	/'twenti/
28	/e/	ten	/ten/
29	/æ/	stamp	/stæmp/
30	/ɑː/	father	/'fɑːðə/
31	/ɒ/	hot	/hɒt/
32	/ɔː/	morning	/'mɔːnɪŋ/
33	/ʊ/	football	/'fʊtbɔːl/
34	/uː/	you	/juː/
35	/ʌ/	sun	/sʌn/
36	/ɜː/	learn	/lɜːn/
37	/ə/	letter	/'letə/

Diphthongs

38	/eɪ/	name	/neɪm/
39	/əʊ/	no	/nəʊ/
40	/aɪ/	my	/maɪ/
41	/aʊ/	how	/haʊ/
42	/ɔɪ/	boy	/bɔɪ/
43	/ɪə/	hear	/hɪə/
44	/eə/	where	/weə/
45	/ʊə/	tour	/tʊə/

An Astrologer's Day

R. K. Narayan

Punctually at midday he opened his bag and spread out his professional equipment, which consisted of a dozen cowrie shells, a square piece of cloth with obscure mystic charts on it, a notebook, and a bundle of palmyra writing. His forehead was resplendent with sacred ash and vermilion, and his eyes sparkled with a sharp abnormal gleam which was really an outcome of a continual searching look for customers, but which his simple clients took to be a prophetic light and felt comforted. The power of his eyes was considerably enhanced by their position placed as they were between the painted forehead and the dark whiskers which streamed down his cheeks. Even a half-wit's eyes would sparkle in such a setting. To crown the effect he wound a saffron-coloured turban around his head. This colour scheme never failed. People were attracted to him as bees are attracted to cosmos or dahlia stalks. He sat under the boughs of a spreading tamarind tree which flanked a path running through the Town Hall Park. It was a remarkable place in many ways: a surging crowd was always moving up and down this narrow road morning till night. A variety of trades and occupations was represented all along its way: medicine sellers, sellers of stolen hardware and junk, magicians, and, above all, an auctioneer of cheap cloth, who created enough din all day to attract the whole town. Next to him in vociferousness came a vendor of fried groundnut, who gave his ware a fancy name each day, calling it "Bombay Ice-Cream" one day, and on the next "Delhi Almond," and on the third "Raja's Delicacy" and so on and so forth, and people flocked to

him. A considerable portion of this crowd dallied before the astrologer too. The astrologer transacted his business by the light of a flare which crackled and smoked up above the groundnut heap nearby. Half the enchantment of the place was due to the fact that it did not have the benefit of municipal lighting. The place was lit up by shop lights.

One or two had hissing gaslights, some had naked flares stuck on poles, some were lit up by old cycle lamps, and one or two, like the astrologer's, managed without lights of their own. It was a bewildering criss-cross of light rays and moving shadows. This suited the astrologer very well, for the simple reason that he had not in the least intended to be an astrologer when he began life; and he knew no more of what was going to happen to others than he knew what was going to happen to himself next minute. He was as much a stranger to the stars as were his innocent customers. Yet he said things which pleased and astonished everyone: that was more a matter of study, practice, and shrewd guesswork. All the same, it was as much an honest man's labour as any other, and he deserved the wages he carried home at the end of a day. He had left his village without any previous thought or plan. If he had continued there he would have carried on the work of his forefathers namely, tilling the land, living, marrying, and ripening in his cornfield and ancestral home. But that was not to be. He had to leave home without telling anyone, and he could not rest till he left it behind a couple of hundred miles. To a villager it is a great deal, as if an ocean flowed between. He had a working analysis of mankind's troubles: marriage, money, and the tangles of human ties. Long practice had sharpened his perception. Within five minutes he understood what was wrong. He charged three pies per question, never opened his mouth till the other had spoken for at least ten minutes, which provided him enough stuff for a dozen answers and advices. When he told the person before him, gazing at his palm, "In many ways you are not getting the fullest results for your efforts," nine out of ten were disposed to agree with him. Or he questioned: "Is there any woman in your family, maybe even a distant relative, who is not well disposed towards you?" Or he gave

an analysis of character: "Most of your troubles are due to your nature. How can you be otherwise with Saturn where he is? You have an impetuous nature and a rough exterior."

This endeared him to their hearts immediately, for even the mildest of us loves to think that he has a forbidding exterior. The nuts vendor blew out his flare and rose to go home. This was a signal for the astrologer to bundle up too, since it left him in darkness except for a little shaft of green light which strayed in from somewhere and touched the ground before him. He picked up his cowrie shells and paraphernalia and was putting them back into his bag when the green shaft of light was blotted out; he looked up and saw a man standing before him. He sensed a possible client and said: "You look so careworn. It will do you good to sit down for a while and chat with me." The other grumbled some reply vaguely. The astrologer pressed his invitation; whereupon the other thrust his palm under his nose, saying: "You call yourself an astrologer?" The astrologer felt challenged and said, tilting the other's palm towards the green shaft of light: "Yours is a nature ..." "Oh, stop that," the other said. "Tell me something worth while..." Our friend felt piqued. "I charge only three pies per question, and what you get ought to be good enough for your money..." At this the other withdrew his arm, took out an anna, and flung it out to him, saying: "I have some questions to ask. If I prove you are bluffing, you must return that anna to me with interest." "If you find my answers satisfactory, will you give me five rupees?" "No." "Or will you give me eight annas?" "All right, provided you give me twice as much if you are wrong," said the stranger. This pact was accepted after a little further argument. The astrologer sent up a prayer to heaven as the other lit a cheroot. The astrologer caught a glimpse of his face by the matchlight. There was a pause as cars hooted on the road and jutka drivers swore at their horses, and the babble of the crowd agitated the semi-darkness of the park.

The other sat down, sucking his cheroot, puffing out, sat there ruthlessly. The astrologer felt very uncomfortable. "Here, take your

anna back. I am not used to such challenges. It is late for me today..." He made preparations to bundle up. The other held his wrist and said: "You can't get out of it now. You dragged me in while I was passing." The astrologer shivered in his grip; and his voice shook and became faint. "Leave me today. I will speak to you tomorrow." The other thrust his palm in his face and said: "Challenge is challenge. Go on." The astrologer proceeded, with his throat drying up: "There is a woman ..." "Stop," said the other. "I don't want all that. Shall I succeed in my present search or not? Answer this and go. Otherwise I will not let you go till you disgorge all your coins." The astrologer muttered a few incantations and replied: "All right. I will speak. But will you give me a rupee if what I say is convincing? Otherwise I will not open my mouth, and you may do what you like." After a good deal of haggling the other agreed. The astrologer said: "You were left for dead. Am I right?" "Ah, tell me more." "A knife has passed through you once?" said the astrologer. "Good fellow!" He bared his chest to show the scar. "What else?" "And then you were pushed into a well nearby in the field. You were left for dead." "I should have been dead if some passer-by had not chanced to peep into the well," exclaimed the other, overwhelmed by enthusiasm. "When shall I get at him?" he asked, clenching his fist. "In the next world," answered the astrologer. "He died four months ago in a far off town. You will never see any more of him."

The other groaned on hearing it. The astrologer proceeded: "Guru Nayak" "You know my name!" the other said, taken aback. "As I know all other things. Guru Nayak, listen carefully to what I have to say. Your village is two days' journey due north of this town. Take the next train and be gone. I see once again great danger to your life if you go from home." He took out a pinch of sacred ash and held it to him. "Rub it on your forehead and go home. Never travel southward again, and you will live to be a hundred." "Why should I leave home again?" the other said reflectively. "I was only going away now and then to look for him and to choke out his life if I met him." He shook his head regretfully. "He has

escaped my hands. I hope at least he died as he deserved." "Yes," said the astrologer. "He was crushed under a lorry." The other looked gratified to hear it. The place was deserted by the time the astrologer picked up his articles and put them into his bag. The green shaft was also gone, leaving the place in darkness. The stranger had gone off into the night, after giving the astrologer a handful of coins. It was nearly midnight when the astrologer reached home. His wife was waiting for him at the door and demanded an explanation. He flung the coins at her and said: "Count them. One man gave all that." "Twelve and a half annas," she said, counting. She was overjoyed. "I can buy some jaggery and coconut tomorrow. The child has been asking for sweets for so many days now. I will prepare some nice stuff for her." "The swine has cheated me! He promised me a rupee," said the astrologer. She looked up at him. "You look worried. What is wrong?" "Nothing."

After dinner, sitting on the pyol, he told her: "Do you know a great load is gone from me today? I thought I had the blood of a man on my hands all these years. That was the reason why I ran away from home, settled here, and married you. He is alive." She gasped. "You tried to kill!" "Yes, in our village, when I was a silly youngster. We drank, gambled, and quarrelled badly one day. Why think of it now? Time to sleep," he said, yawning, and stretched himself on the pyol.

Week three

Drama

18–24 August

The Merchant of Venice

A summary

Course handout

In Shakespeare's *The Merchant of Venice*, a merchant named Antonio borrows money from a Jewish moneylender, Shylock, to help his friend Bassanio woo an heiress named Portia. When Antonio's ships are lost at sea, he defaults on the loan, leading to a dramatic courtroom trial where Portia saves Antonio's life.

The loan and the bond

- Bassanio needs money to travel to Belmont and court Portia.
- Antonio's money is tied up in merchant ships, so he uses his credit to back a loan from Shylock.
- Shylock, who hates Antonio for his insults and anti-Semitism, agrees to lend 3,000 ducats with no interest.
- The catch: if Antonio fails to repay the debt on time, Shylock can cut a pound of flesh from Antonio's body.
- Portia's father leaves a test; suitors must choose correctly from a gold, silver, or lead casket to win her hand.
- Bassanio picks the correct lead casket and wins Portia.
- Antonio's trading ships are reported lost at sea, meaning he cannot pay back the loan, and Shylock demands his pound of flesh.

The Courtroom Trial

- Portia disguises herself as a young male lawyer named Balthazar, and her maid Nerissa poses as her clerk.
- Portia tells Shylock to show mercy, but he demands the strict execution of the law.
- Portia agrees the bond is legal, but adds a strict condition: the contract allows for flesh, but not a single drop of blood.
- If Shylock sheds a drop of blood while cutting the flesh, his lands and goods will be seized by the state of Venice.

Resolution

- Defeated by the legal loophole, Shylock loses his wealth, half going to the state and half to his daughter Jessica.

The Merchant of Venice

Act IV, Scene i

William Shakespeare

Venice. A court of justice.

Enter the Duke: the Magnificoes; Antonio, Bassanio, Gratiano, Salarino, Salanio, and Others.

Duke

What, is Antonio here?

Antonio

Ready, so please your Grace.

Duke

I am sorry for thee; thou art come to answer
A stony adversary, an inhuman wretch,
Uncapable of pity, void and empty
From any dram of mercy.

Antonio

I have heard
Your Grace hath ta'en great pains to qualify
His rigorous course; but since he stands obdurate,
And that no lawful means can carry me
Out of his envy's reach, I do oppose

My patience to his fury, and am arm'd
To suffer with a quietness of spirit
The very tyranny and rage of his.

Duke

Go one, and call the Jew into the court.

Salarino

He is ready at the door; he comes, my lord.

Enter Shylock.

Duke

Make room, and let him stand before our face.
Shylock, the world thinks, and I think so too,
That thou but leadest this fashion of thy malice
To the last hour of act; and then, 'tis thought,
Thou'lt show thy mercy and remorse, more strange
Than is thy strange apparent cruelty;
And where thou now exacts the penalty,—
Which is a pound of this poor merchant's flesh,—
Thou wilt not only loose the forfeiture,
But, touch'd with human gentleness and love,
Forgive a moiety of the principal,
Glancing an eye of pity on his losses,
That have of late so huddled on his back,
Enow to press a royal merchant down,
And pluck commiseration of his state
From brassy bosoms and rough hearts of flint,
From stubborn Turks and Tartars, never train'd
To offices of tender courtesy.
We all expect a gentle answer, Jew.

Shylock

I have possess'd your Grace of what I purpose,

And by our holy Sabbath have I sworn
To have the due and forfeit of my bond.
If you deny it, let the danger light
Upon your charter and your city's freedom.
You'll ask me why I rather choose to have
A weight of carrion flesh than to receive
Three thousand ducats. I'll not answer that,
But say it is my humour: is it answer'd?
What if my house be troubled with a rat,
And I be pleas'd to give ten thousand ducats
To have it ban'd? What, are you answer'd yet?
Some men there are love not a gaping pig;
Some that are mad if they behold a cat;
And others, when the bagpipe sings i' the nose,
Cannot contain their urine; for affection,
Mistress of passion, sways it to the mood
Of what it likes or loathes. Now, for your answer:
As there is no firm reason to be render'd,
Why he cannot abide a gaping pig;
Why he, a harmless necessary cat;
Why he, a wauling bagpipe; but of force
Must yield to such inevitable shame
As to offend, himself being offended;
So can I give no reason, nor I will not,
More than a lodg'd hate and a certain loathing
I bear Antonio, that I follow thus
A losing suit against him. Are you answered?

Bassanio

This is no answer, thou unfeeling man,
To excuse the current of thy cruelty.

Shylock

I am not bound to please thee with my answer.

Bassanio

Do all men kill the things they do not love?

Shylock

Hates any man the thing he would not kill?

Bassanio

Every offence is not a hate at first.

Shylock

What! wouldst thou have a serpent sting thee twice?

Antonio

I pray you, think you question with the Jew:
You may as well go stand upon the beach,
And bid the main flood bate his usual height;
You may as well use question with the wolf,
Why he hath made the ewe bleat for the lamb;
You may as well forbid the mountain pines
To wag their high tops and to make no noise
When they are fretten with the gusts of heaven;
You may as well do anything most hard
As seek to soften that—than which what's harder?—
His Jewish heart: therefore, I do beseech you,
Make no moe offers, use no farther means,
But with all brief and plain conveniency.
Let me have judgment, and the Jew his will.

Bassanio

For thy three thousand ducats here is six.

Shylock

If every ducat in six thousand ducats
Were in six parts, and every part a ducat,
I would not draw them; I would have my bond.

Duke

How shalt thou hope for mercy, rendering none?

Shylock

What judgment shall I dread, doing no wrong?
You have among you many a purchas'd slave,
Which, like your asses and your dogs and mules,
You use in abject and in slavish parts,
Because you bought them; shall I say to you
'Let them be free, marry them to your heirs!
Why sweat they under burdens? let their beds
Be made as soft as yours, and let their palates
Be season'd with such viands? You will answer
'The slaves are ours.' So do I answer you:
The pound of flesh which I demand of him
Is dearly bought; 'tis mine, and I will have it.
If you deny me, fie upon your law!
There is no force in the decrees of Venice.
I stand for judgment: answer; shall I have it?

Duke

Upon my power I may dismiss this court,
Unless Bellario, a learned doctor,
Whom I have sent for to determine this,
Come here to-day.

Salarino

My lord, here stays without
A messenger with letters from the doctor,

New come from Padua.

Duke
Bring us the letters; call the messenger.

Bassanio
Good cheer, Antonio! What, man, courage yet!
The Jew shall have my flesh, blood, bones, and all,
Ere thou shalt lose for me one drop of blood.

Antonio
I am a tainted wether of the flock,
Meetest for death; the weakest kind of fruit
Drops earliest to the ground, and so let me.
You cannot better be employ'd, Bassanio,
Than to live still, and write mine epitaph.

Enter Nerissa dressed like a lawyer's clerk.

Duke
Came you from Padua, from Bellario?

Nerissa
From both, my lord. Bellario greets your Grace.
Presents a letter.

Bassanio
Why dost thou whet thy knife so earnestly?

Shylock
To cut the forfeiture from that bankrupt there.

Gratiano
Not on thy sole, but on thy soul, harsh Jew,
Thou mak'st thy knife keen; but no metal can,
No, not the hangman's axe, bear half the keenness
Of thy sharp envy. Can no prayers pierce thee?

Shylock

No, none that thou hast wit enough to make.

Gratiano

O, be thou damn'd, inexecrable dog!
And for thy life let justice be accus'd.
Thou almost mak'st me waver in my faith,
To hold opinion with Pythagoras
That souls of animals infuse themselves
Into the trunks of men. Thy currish spirit
Govern'd a wolf who, hang'd for human slaughter,
Even from the gallows did his fell soul fleet,
And, whilst thou lay'st in thy unhallow'd dam,
Infus'd itself in thee; for thy desires
Are wolfish, bloody, starv'd and ravenous.

Shylock

Till thou canst rail the seal from off my bond,
Thou but offend'st thy lungs to speak so loud;
Repair thy wit, good youth, or it will fall
To cureless ruin. I stand here for law.

Duke

This letter from Bellario doth commend
A young and learned doctor to our court.
Where is he?

Nerissa

He attendeth here hard by,
To know your answer, whether you'll admit him.

Duke

With all my heart: some three or four of you
Go give him courteous conduct to this place.
Meantime, the court shall hear Bellario's letter.

Clerk

'Your Grace shall understand that at the receipt of your letter I am very sick;
but in the instant that your messenger came, in loving visitation was with
me a young doctor of Rome; his name is Balthazar. I acquainted him with
the cause in controversy between the Jew and Antonio the merchant; we turn'd
o'er many books together; he is furnished with my opinion which, bettered with
his own learning,—the greatness whereof I cannot enough commend,—comes
with him at my importunity to fill up your Grace's request in my stead. I
beseech you let his lack of years be no impediment to let him lack a reverend
estimation, for I never knew so young a body with so old a head. I leave him to
your gracious acceptance, whose trial shall better publish his commendation.'

Duke

You hear the learn'd Bellario, what he writes;
And here, I take it, is the doctor come.

Enter Portia, dressed like a doctor of laws.

Give me your hand; come you from old Bellario?

Portia

I did, my lord.

Duke

You are welcome; take your place.

Are you acquainted with the difference
That holds this present question in the court?

Portia

I am informed throughly of the cause.
Which is the merchant here, and which the Jew?

Duke

Antonio and old Shylock, both stand forth.

Portia

Is your name Shylock?

Shylock

Shylock is my name.

Portia

Of a strange nature is the suit you follow;
Yet in such rule that the Venetian law
Cannot impugn you as you do proceed.
To Antonio. You stand within his danger, do you not?

Antonio

Ay, so he says.

Portia

Do you confess the bond?

Antonio

I do.

Portia

Then must the Jew be merciful.

Shylock

On what compulsion must I? Tell me that.

Portia

The quality of mercy is not strain'd;
It droppeth as the gentle rain from heaven
Upon the place beneath. It is twice blest:
It blesseth him that gives and him that takes.
'Tis mightiest in the mightiest; it becomes
The throned monarch better than his crown;
His sceptre shows the force of temporal power,
The attribute to awe and majesty,
Wherein doth sit the dread and fear of kings;
But mercy is above this sceptred sway,
It is enthroned in the hearts of kings,
It is an attribute to God himself;
And earthly power doth then show likest God's
When mercy seasons justice. Therefore, Jew,
Though justice be thy plea, consider this,
That in the course of justice none of us
Should see salvation; we do pray for mercy,
And that same prayer doth teach us all to render
The deeds of mercy. I have spoke thus much
To mitigate the justice of thy plea,
Which if thou follow, this strict court of Venice
Must needs give sentence 'gainst the merchant there.

Shylock

My deeds upon my head! I crave the law,
The penalty and forfeit of my bond.

Portia

Is he not able to discharge the money?

Bassanio

Yes; here I tender it for him in the court;
Yea, twice the sum; if that will not suffice,

I will be bound to pay it ten times o'er
On forfeit of my hands, my head, my heart;
If this will not suffice, it must appear
That malice bears down truth. And, I beseech you,
Wrest once the law to your authority;
To do a great right do a little wrong,
And curb this cruel devil of his will.

Portia

It must not be; there is no power in Venice
Can alter a decree established;
'Twill be recorded for a precedent,
And many an error by the same example
Will rush into the state. It cannot be.

Shylock

A Daniel come to judgment! Yea, a Daniel!
O wise young judge, how I do honour thee!

Portia

I pray you, let me look upon the bond.

Shylock

Here 'tis, most reverend doctor; here it is.

Portia

Shylock, there's thrice thy money offer'd thee.

Shylock

An oath, an oath! I have an oath in heaven.
Shall I lay perjury upon my soul?
No, not for Venice.

Portia

Why, this bond is forfeit;

And lawfully by this the Jew may claim
A pound of flesh, to be by him cut off
Nearest the merchant's heart. Be merciful.
Take thrice thy money; bid me tear the bond.

Shylock

When it is paid according to the tenour.
It doth appear you are a worthy judge;
You know the law; your exposition
Hath been most sound; I charge you by the law,
Whereof you are a well-deserving pillar,
Proceed to judgment. By my soul I swear
There is no power in the tongue of man
To alter me. I stay here on my bond.

Antonio

Most heartily I do beseech the court
To give the judgment.

Portia

Why then, thus it is:
You must prepare your bosom for his knife.

Shylock

O noble judge! O excellent young man!

Portia

For the intent and purpose of the law
Hath full relation to the penalty,
Which here appeareth due upon the bond.

Shylock

'Tis very true. O wise and upright judge,
How much more elder art thou than thy looks!

Portia

Therefore, lay bare your bosom.

Shylock

Ay, 'his breast':
So says the bond:—doth it not, noble judge?—
'Nearest his heart': those are the very words.

Portia

It is so. Are there balance here to weigh
The flesh?

Shylock

I have them ready.

Portia

Have by some surgeon, Shylock, on your charge,
To stop his wounds, lest he do bleed to death.

Shylock

Is it so nominated in the bond?

Portia

It is not so express'd; but what of that?
'Twere good you do so much for charity.

Shylock

I cannot find it; 'tis not in the bond.

Portia

You, merchant, have you anything to say?

Antonio

But little: I am arm'd and well prepar'd.
Give me your hand, Bassanio: fare you well:
Grieve not that I am fallen to this for you,

For herein Fortune shows herself more kind
Than is her custom: it is still her use
To let the wretched man outlive his wealth,
To view with hollow eye and wrinkled brow
An age of poverty; from which lingering penance
Of such misery doth she cut me off.
Commend me to your honourable wife:
Tell her the process of Antonio's end;
Say how I lov'd you; speak me fair in death;
And, when the tale is told, bid her be judge
Whether Bassanio had not once a love.
Repent but you that you shall lose your friend,
And he repents not that he pays your debt;
For if the Jew do cut but deep enough,
I'll pay it instantly with all my heart.

Bassanio

Antonio, I am married to a wife
Which is as dear to me as life itself;
But life itself, my wife, and all the world,
Are not with me esteem'd above thy life;
I would lose all, ay, sacrifice them all
Here to this devil, to deliver you.

Portia

Your wife would give you little thanks for that,
If she were by to hear you make the offer.

Gratiano

I have a wife whom, I protest, I love;
I would she were in heaven, so she could
Entreat some power to change this currish Jew.

Nerissa

'Tis well you offer it behind her back;
The wish would make else an unquiet house.

Shylock

These be the Christian husbands! I have a daughter;
Would any of the stock of Barabbas
Had been her husband, rather than a Christian!
We trifle time; I pray thee, pursue sentence.

Portia

A pound of that same merchant's flesh is thine.
The court awards it and the law doth give it.

Shylock

Most rightful judge!

Portia

And you must cut this flesh from off his breast.
The law allows it and the court awards it.

Shylock

Most learned judge! A sentence! Come, prepare.

Portia

Tarry a little; there is something else.
This bond doth give thee here no jot of blood;
The words expressly are 'a pound of flesh':
Take then thy bond, take thou thy pound of flesh;
But, in the cutting it, if thou dost shed
One drop of Christian blood, thy lands and goods
Are, by the laws of Venice, confiscate
Unto the state of Venice.

Gratiano
O upright judge! Mark, Jew: O learned judge!

Shylock
Is that the law?

Portia
Thyself shalt see the act;
For, as thou urgest justice, be assur'd
Thou shalt have justice, more than thou desir'st.

Gratiano
O learned judge! Mark, Jew: a learned judge!

Shylock
I take this offer then: pay the bond thrice,
And let the Christian go.

Bassanio
Here is the money.

Portia
Soft!
The Jew shall have all justice; soft! no haste:—
He shall have nothing but the penalty.

Gratiano
O Jew! an upright judge, a learned judge!

Portia
Therefore, prepare thee to cut off the flesh.
Shed thou no blood; nor cut thou less nor more,
But just a pound of flesh: if thou tak'st more,
Or less, than a just pound, be it but so much
As makes it light or heavy in the substance,
Or the division of the twentieth part

Of one poor scruple; nay, if the scale do turn
But in the estimation of a hair,
Thou diest, and all thy goods are confiscate.

Gratiano

A second Daniel, a Daniel, Jew!
Now, infidel, I have you on the hip.

Portia

Why doth the Jew pause? Take thy forfeiture.

Shylock

Give me my principal, and let me go.

Bassanio

I have it ready for thee; here it is.

Portia

He hath refus'd it in the open court;
He shall have merely justice, and his bond.

Gratiano

A Daniel still say I; a second Daniel!
I thank thee, Jew, for teaching me that word.

Shylock

Shall I not have barely my principal?

Portia

Thou shalt have nothing but the forfeiture
To be so taken at thy peril, Jew.

Shylock

Why, then the devil give him good of it!
I'll stay no longer question.

Portia

Tarry, Jew.
The law hath yet another hold on you.
It is enacted in the laws of Venice,
If it be prov'd against an alien
That by direct or indirect attempts
He seek the life of any citizen,
The party 'gainst the which he doth contrive
Shall seize one half his goods; the other half
Comes to the privy coffer of the state;
And the offender's life lies in the mercy
Of the duke only, 'gainst all other voice.
In which predicament, I say, thou stand'st;
For it appears by manifest proceeding
That indirectly, and directly too,
Thou hast contrived against the very life
Of the defendant; and thou hast incurr'd
The danger formerly by me rehears'd.
Down, therefore, and beg mercy of the duke.

Gratiano

Beg that thou mayst have leave to hang thyself;
And yet, thy wealth being forfeit to the state,
Thou hast not left the value of a cord;
Therefore thou must be hang'd at the state's charge.

Duke

That thou shalt see the difference of our spirits,
I pardon thee thy life before thou ask it.
For half thy wealth, it is Antonio's;
The other half comes to the general state,
Which humbleness may drive unto a fine.

Portia

Ay, for the state; not for Antonio.

Shylock

Nay, take my life and all, pardon not that:
You take my house when you do take the prop
That doth sustain my house; you take my life
When you do take the means whereby I live.

Portia

What mercy can you render him, Antonio?

Gratiano

A halter gratis; nothing else, for God's sake!

Antonio

So please my lord the Duke and all the court
To quit the fine for one half of his goods;
I am content, so he will let me have
The other half in use, to render it
Upon his death unto the gentleman
That lately stole his daughter:
Two things provided more, that, for this favour,
He presently become a Christian;
The other, that he do record a gift,
Here in the court, of all he dies possess'd
Unto his son Lorenzo and his daughter.

Duke

He shall do this, or else I do recant
The pardon that I late pronounced here.

Portia

Art thou contented, Jew? What dost thou say?

Shylock

I am content.

Portia

Clerk, draw a deed of gift.

Shylock

I pray you, give me leave to go from hence;
I am not well; send the deed after me
And I will sign it.

Duke

Get thee gone, but do it.

Gratiano

In christening shalt thou have two god-fathers;
Had I been judge, thou shouldst have had ten more,
To bring thee to the gallows, not to the font.

Exit Shylock.

Duke

Sir, I entreat you home with me to dinner.

Portia

I humbly do desire your Grace of pardon;
I must away this night toward Padua,
And it is meet I presently set forth.

Duke

I am sorry that your leisure serves you not.
Antonio, gratify this gentleman,
For in my mind you are much bound to him.

Exeunt Duke, Magnificoes, and Train.

Bassanio

Most worthy gentleman, I and my friend
Have by your wisdom been this day acquitted
Of grievous penalties; in lieu whereof
Three thousand ducats, due unto the Jew,
We freely cope your courteous pains withal.

Antonio

And stand indebted, over and above,
In love and service to you evermore.

Portia

He is well paid that is well satisfied;
And I, delivering you, am satisfied,
And therein do account myself well paid:
My mind was never yet more mercenary.
I pray you, know me when we meet again:
I wish you well, and so I take my leave.

Bassanio

Dear sir, of force I must attempt you further;
Take some remembrance of us, as a tribute,
Not as fee. Grant me two things, I pray you,
Not to deny me, and to pardon me.

Portia

You press me far, and therefore I will yield.
To Antonio
Give me your gloves, I'll wear them for your sake.
To Bassanio
And, for your love, I'll take this ring from you.
Do not draw back your hand; I'll take no more;
And you in love shall not deny me this.

Bassanio

This ring, good sir? alas, it is a trifle;
I will not shame myself to give you this.

Portia

I will have nothing else but only this;
And now, methinks, I have a mind to it.

Bassanio

There's more depends on this than on the value.
The dearest ring in Venice will I give you,
And find it out by proclamation:
Only for this, I pray you, pardon me.

Portia

I see, sir, you are liberal in offers;
You taught me first to beg, and now methinks
You teach me how a beggar should be answer'd.

Bassanio

Good sir, this ring was given me by my wife;
And, when she put it on, she made me vow
That I should neither sell, nor give, nor lose it.

Portia

That 'scuse serves many men to save their gifts.
And if your wife be not a mad-woman,
And know how well I have deserv'd this ring,
She would not hold out enemy for ever
For giving it to me. Well, peace be with you!

Exeunt Portia and Nerissa.

Antonio

My Lord Bassanio, let him have the ring:
Let his deservings, and my love withal,

Be valued 'gainst your wife's commandment.

Bassanio

Go, Gratiano, run and overtake him;
Give him the ring, and bring him, if thou canst,
Unto Antonio's house. Away! make haste.

Exit Gratiano.

Come, you and I will thither presently;
And in the morning early will we both
Fly toward Belmont. Come, Antonio.

Exeunt.

Week five

The Short Story & Biography

1–7 September

The Refugee

Pearl S. Buck

They walked through the new capital, alien and from a far country, yes, although their own lands were only a few hundred miles perhaps from this very street upon which they now walked. But to them it was very far. Their eyes were the eyes of those who have been taken suddenly and by some unaccountable force from the world they have always known and always thought safe until this time. They who had been accustomed only to country roads and fields, walked now along the proud street of the new capital, their feet treading upon the new concrete sidewalk, and although the street was full of things they had never seen before, so that there were even automobiles and such things of which they had never even heard, still they looked at nothing, but passed as in a dream, seeing nothing.

There were several hundred of them passing at this moment. If they did not look at anything nor at anyone, neither did any look at them. The city was full of refugees, many thousands of them, fed after a fashion, clothed somehow, sheltered in mats in great camps outside the city wall. At any hour of the day lines of ragged men and women and a few children could be seen making their way towards the camps, and if any city dweller noticed them it was to think with increased bitterness:

"More refugees—will there never be an end to them? We will all starve trying to feed them even a little!"

This bitterness, which is the bitterness of fear, made small shopkeepers bawl out rudely to the many beggars who came hourly to beg at the

doors, and it made men ruthless in paying small fares to the rickshaw pullers, of which there were ten times as many as could be used, because the refugees were trying to earn something thus. Even the usual pullers of rickshaws who followed this as their profession cursed the refugees because, being starving, they would pull for anything given them, and so fares were low for all, and all suffered. With the city full of refugees, then, begging at every door, swarming into every unskilled trade and service, lying dead on the streets at every frozen dawn, why should one look at this fresh horde coming in now at twilight of a winter's day?

But these were no common men and women, no riff-raff from some community always poor and easily starving in a flood time. No, these were men and women of which any nation might have been proud. It could be seen they were all from one region, for they wore garments woven out of the same dark blue cotton stuff, plain and cut in an old-fashioned way, the sleeves long and the coats long and full. The men wore smocked aprons, the smocking done in curious, intricate, beautiful designs. The women had bands of the same plain blue stuff wrapped like kerchiefs about their heads. Both men and women were tall and strong in frame, although the women's feet were bound. There were a few lads in the throng, a few children sitting in baskets slung upon a pole across the shoulders of their fathers, but there were no young girls, no young infants. Every man and every lad bore a burden on his shoulder. This burden was always bedding, quilts made of the blue cotton stuff and padded. Clothing and bedding were clean and strongly made. On top of every folded quilt, with a bit of mat between, was an iron cauldron. These cauldrons had doubtless been taken from the earthen ovens of the village when the people saw the time had come when they must move. But in no basket was there a vestige of food, nor was there a trace of food having been cooked in them recently.

This lack of food was confirmed when one looked closely into the faces of the people. In the first glance in the twilight they seemed well enough, but when one looked more closely one saw they were the faces

of people starving and moving now in despair to a last hope. They saw nothing of the strange sights of a new city because they were too near death to see anything. No new sight could move their curiosity. They were men and women who had stayed by their land until starvation drove them forth. Thus they passed unseeing, silent, alien, as those who know themselves dying are alien to the living.

The last one of this long procession of silent men and women was a little wizened old man. Even he carried a load of two baskets, slung on a pole on his shoulder, the same load of a folded quilt, a cauldron. But there was only one cauldron. In the other basket it seemed there was but a quilt, extremely ragged and patched, but clean still. Although the load was light it was too much for the old man. It was evident that in usual times he would be beyond the age of work, and was perhaps unaccustomed to such labour in recent years. His breath whistled as he staggered along, and he strained his eyes to watch those who were ahead of him lest he be left behind, and his old wrinkled face was set in a sort of gasping agony.

Suddenly he could go no more. He set his burden down with great gentleness and sank upon the ground, his head sunk between his knees, his eyes closed, panting desperately. Starved as he was, a little blood rose in dark patches on his cheeks. A ragged vendor selling hot noodles set his stand near, and shouted his trade cry, and the light from the stand fell on the old man's drooping figure. A man passing stopped and muttered, looking at him:

"I swear I can give no more this day if I am to feed my own even nothing but noodles—but here is this old man. Well, I will give him the bit of silver I earned today against tomorrow and trust to tomorrow again. If my own old father had been alive I would have given it to him."

He fumbled in himself and brought out of his ragged girdle a bit of a silver coin, and after a moment's hesitation and muttering, he added to it a copper penny.

"There, old father," he said with a sort of bitter heartiness, "let me see you eat noodles!"

The old man lifted his head slowly. When he saw the silver he would not put out his hand. He said:

"Sir, I did not beg of you. Sir, we have good land and we have never been starving like this before, having such good land. But this year the river rose and men starve even on good land at such times. Sir, we have no seed left, even. We have eaten our seed. I told them, we cannot eat the seed. But they were young and hungry and they ate it."

"Take it," said the man, and he dropped the money into the old man's smocked apron and went on his way, sighing.

The vendor prepared his bowl of noodles and called out:

"How many will you eat, old man?"

Then was the old man stirred. He felt eagerly in his apron and when he saw the two coins there, the one copper and the other silver, he said:

"One small bowl is enough."

"Can you eat only one small bowl, then?" asked the vendor, astonished.

"It is not for me," the old man answered.

The vendor stared astonished, but being a simple man he said no more but prepared the bowl, and when it was finished he called out, "Here it is!" And he waited to see who would eat it.

Then the old man rose with a great effort and took the bowl between his shaking hands and he went to the other basket. There, while the vendor watched, the old man pulled aside the quilt until one could see the shrunken face of a small boy lying with his eyes fast closed. One would have said the child was dead except that when the old man lifted his head so his mouth could touch the edge of the little bowl he began to swallow feebly until the hot mixture was finished. The old man kept murmuring to him:

"There, my heart—there, my child—"

"Your grandson?" said the vendor.

"Yes," said the old man. "The son of my only son. Both my son and his wife were drowned as they worked on our land when the dikes broke."

He covered the child tenderly and then, squatting on his haunches, he ran his tongue carefully around the little bowl and removed the last trace of food. Then, as though he had been fed, he handed the bowl back to the vendor.

"But you have the silver bit!" cried the ragged vendor, yet more astonished when he saw the old man ordered no more.

The old man shook his head. "That is for seed," he replied. "As soon as I saw it, I knew I would buy seed with it. They ate up all the seed, and with what shall the land be sown again?"

"If I were not so poor myself," said the vendor, "I might even have given you a bowl. But to give something to a man who has a bit of silver—" He shook his head, puzzled.[1]

"I do not ask you, brother," said the old man. "Well I know you cannot understand. But if you had land you would know it must be put to seed again or there will be starvation yet another year. The best I can do for this grandson of mine is to buy a little seed for the land—yes, even though I die, and others must plant it, the land must be put to seed."

He took up his load again, his old legs trembling, and straining his eyes down the long straight street, he staggered on.

BIOGRAPHICAL NOTES

Pearl Buck was an American novelist, story writer, dramatist and biographer. She was born in Hillsboro, West Virginia, in 1892, the daughter of Presbyterian missionaries. She went to China with her parents and grew up there. After spending some time at a Shanghai boarding school she returned to the USA to go to college and university. She taught psychology for a while in Virginia, then returned in 1921 to Nanking, to work as an English teacher.

---

[1] *puzzled*: perplexed, unable to understand.

Pearl S. Buck started writing relatively early, but did not achieve success until 1931 with her second novel The Good Earth. The novel made a deep impression because of its powerful and sympathetic understanding of working people in China. In 1938 she became the first American woman to receive the Nobel Prize for Literature.

Pearl S. Buck was involved in many different humanitarian organizations and also worked to encourage Chinese-American understanding. She was married twice and adopted eight children. She died in 1973.

Srinivasa Ramanujan

C. P. Snow

INTRODUCTION

Srinivasa Ramanujan was born in Erode in 1887. He had his schooling at Kumbakonam, a small temple town in South India. His obsession with mathematics was such that at age 13 he mastered trigonometry and made his own theorems. But since he was not good in other subjects he could not complete his degree. He worked in the Madras Port Trust, where, after completing his office work, he would pursue his own research in mathematics.

His life underwent a sea change when his genius was recognized by the great mathematician Hardy and Ramanujan sailed to Cambridge in 1914. After the completion of his research he was made the fellow of the Royal Society in 1918. He also became the first Indian Fellow of Trinity College, Cambridge. He returned to India in 1919 but his ill-health took its toll and he died the same year when he was hardly 33.

ABOUT THE TEXT

This extract is from the book *Variety of Men* by C.P. Snow. This passage on Ramanujan, is a part of the biographical sketch of the mathematician Hardy and it tells us how Hardy 'discovered' Ramanujan. Ramanujan had sent to Hardy some theorems without proofs and had asked for his opinion. Hardy at first wondered if it was the work of a fraud, but was later convinced that Ramanujan was really a genius. Hardy arranged

to bring Ramanujan to Cambridge in 1914. Ramanujan worked hard in Cambridge for five years. Hardy and Ramanujan together produced five papers of the highest class. This extract brings out the genius as well as the fine human qualities in both Hardy and Ramanujan.

About his discovery of Ramanujan, Hardy showed no secrecy at all. It was, he wrote, the one romantic incident in his life: anyway, it is an admirable story, and one which showers credit on nearly everyone (with two exceptions) in it. One morning, early in 1913, he found, among the letters on his breakfast table, a large untidy envelope decorated with Indian stamps. When he opened it, he found sheets of paper by no means clean, on which, in a non-English script, were line after line of symbols. Hardy glanced at them without enthusiasm. He was by this time, at the age of thirty-six, a world famous mathematician; and world famous mathematicians, he had discovered, are unusually exposed to cranks. He was accustomed to receiving manuscripts from strangers, proving the prophetic wisdom of the Great Pyramid, the revelations of the Elders of Zion, or the cryptograms that Bacon had inserted in the plays of the so-called Shakespeare.

So Hardy felt, more than anything, bored. He glanced at the letter, written in halting English, signed by an unknown Indian, asking him to give an opinion of these mathematical discoveries. The script appeared to consist of theorems, most of them, wild or fantastic looking, one or two already well-known, laid out as though they were original. There were no proofs of any kind. Hardy was not only bored, but irritated. It seemed like a curious kind of fraud. He put the manuscript aside, and went on with his day's routine. Since his routine did not vary throughout his life, it is possible to reconstruct it. First he read the *Times* over his breakfast. This happened in January, and if there were any Australian cricket scores, he would start with them, studied with clarity and intense attention.

Then, from about nine to one, unless he was giving a lecture, he worked at his own mathematics. Four hours' creative work a day is about the limit for a mathematician, he used to say. Lunch, a light meal, in hall. After lunch he loped off for a real game of tennis in the university court. (If it had been summer, he would have walked down to Fenner's to watch cricket.) In the late afternoon, a stroll back to his rooms. That particular day, though, while the time-table wasn't altered, internally things were not going according to plan. At the back of his mind, getting in the way of his complete pleasure in his game, the Indian manuscript nagged away. Wild theorems. Theorems such as he had never seen before, nor imagined. A fraud of A question was forming itself in his mind. As it was Hardy's mind, the question was forming itself with epigrammatic clarity: is a fraud of genius more probable than an unknown mathematician of genius?

Clearly the answer was no. Back in his rooms in Trinity, he had another look at the script. He sent word to Littlewood (probably by messenger, certainly not by telephone, for which, like all mechanical contrivances including fountain pens, he had a deep distrust) that they must have a discussion after all.

When the meal was over, there may have been a slight delay. Hardy liked a glass of wine, but, despite the glorious vistas of "Alan St. Aubyn" which had fired his youthful imagination, he found he did not really enjoy lingering in the combination-room over port and walnuts. Littlewood, a good deal more pleasure-loving, did. So there may have been a delay. Anyway, by nine o'clock or so they were in one of Hardy's rooms, with the manuscript stretched out in front That is an occasion at which one would have liked to be present. Hardy with his combination of remorseless clarity and intellectual dash (he was very English, but in argument he showed the characteristics that Latin minds have often assumed to be their own). Littlewood, imaginative, powerful, humorous. Apparently it did not take them long. Before midnight they knew, and knew for certain. The writer of these manuscripts was a man of genius. That

was as much as they could judge, that night. It was only later that Hardy decided that Ramanujan was, in terms of natural mathematical genius, in the class of Gauss and Euler; but that he could not expect, because of the defects of his education and because he had come on the scene too late in the line of mathematical history, to make a contribution on the same scale.

It all sounds easy, the kind of judgment great mathematicians should have been able to make. But I mentioned there were two persons who do not come out of the story with credit. Out of chivalry Hardy concealed this in all that he said or wrote about Ramanujan. The two people concerned have now been dead, however, for many years, and it is time to tell the truth. It is simple. Hardy was not the first eminent mathematician to be sent the Ramanujan manuscripts. There had been two before him, both English, both of the highest professional standing. They had each returned the manuscript without comment. I don't think history relates what they said, if anything, when Ramanujan became famous. Anyone who has been sent unsolicited material will have a sneaking sympathy with them.

Anyway, the following day Hardy went into action. Ramanujan must be brought to England, Hardy decided. Money was not a major problem. Trinity has usually been good at supporting unorthodox talent (the college did the same for Kapitsa a few years later). Once Hardy was determined, no human agency could have stopped Ramanujan, but they needed a certain amount of help from a superhuman one.

Ramanujan turned out to be a poor clerk in Madras, living with his wife on twenty pounds a year. But he was also a Brahmin, usually strict about his religious observances, with a mother who was even stricter. It seemed impossible that he could break the ban and cross the waters. Fortunately his mother had the highest respect for the goddess of Namakkal. One morning Ramanujan's mother made a startling announcement. She had a dream the previous night in which she saw her son seated in a big hall among a group of Europeans and the goddess of Namakkal had com-

manded her not to stand in the way of her son fulfilling his life's purpose. This, say Ramanujan's Indian biographers, was a very agreeable surprise to all concerned.

In 1914 Ramanujan arrived in England. So far as Hardy could detect (though in this respect I should not trust his insight far) Ramanujan, despite the difficulties of breaking the caste laws, did not believe much in theological doctrine, except for a vague pantheistic benevolence, any more than Hardy did himself. But he did certainly believe in ritual. When Trinity put him up in college—within four years he became a Fellow—there was no "Alan St. Aubyn" self-indulgence for him at all. Hardy used to find him ritually changing into his pyjamas, cooking vegetables rather miserably in a frying-pan in his own room.

Their association was a strangely touching one. Hardy did not forget that he was in the presence of genius; but genius that was, even in mathematics, almost untrained. Ramanujan had not been able to enter Madras University because he could not matriculate in English. According to Hardy's report, he was always amiable and good-natured, but no doubt he sometimes found Hardy's conversation outside mathematics more than a little baffling. He seemed to have listened with a patient smile on his good, friendly, homely face. Even inside mathematics they had to come to terms with the difference in their education. Ramanujan was self-taught; he knew nothing of the modern rigour; in a sense he didn't know what a proof was. In an uncharacteristically sentimental moment, Hardy once wrote that if he had been better educated, he would have been less Ramanujan. Coming back to his ironic senses, Hardy later corrected himself and said that the statement was nonsense. If Ramanujan had been better educated, he would have been even more wonderful than he was. In fact, Hardy was obliged to teach him some formal mathematics as though Ramanujan had been a scholarship candidate at Winchester. Hardy said that this was the most singular experience of his life; what did modern mathematics look like to someone who had the deepest insight, but who had literally never heard Anyway, they produced together five

papers of the highest class, in which Hardy showed supreme originality of his own (more is known of the details of this collaboration than of the Hardy-Littlewood one). Generosity and imagination were, for once, rewarded in full.

This is a story of human virtue. Once people had started behaving well, they went on behaving better. It is good to remember that England gave Ramanujan such honours as were possible. The Royal Society elected him a Fellow at the age of thirty (which, even for a mathematician, is very young). Trinity also elected him a Fellow in the same year. He was the first Indian to be given either of these distinctions. He was amiably grateful. But he soon became ill.

Hardy used to visit him, as he lay dying in hospital at Putney. It was on one of those visits that there happened the incident of the taxi-cab number. Hardy had gone out to Putney by taxi, as usual his chosen method of conveyance. He went into the room where Ramanujan was lying. Hardy, always clumsy about introducing a conversation, said, probably without a greeting and certainly as his first remark: "The number of my taxi-cab was 1729. It seems to me rather a dull number." To which Ramanujan replied: "No, Hardy! No, Hardy! It is a very interesting number. It is the smallest number expressible as the sum of two cubes in two different ways."

This is the exchange as Hardy recorded it. It must be substantially accurate. He was the most honest of men and further, no one could possibly have invented it.

It was difficult, in wartime, to move Ramanujan to a kinder climate. He died of tuberculosis, back in Madras, two years after the war. As Hardy wrote in the *Apology*, in his roll-call of mathematicians: "Galois died at twenty-one, Abel at twenty-seven, Ramanujan at thirty-three, Riemann at forty. I do not know an instance of a major mathematical advance initiated by a man past fifty."

Week six

The Dramatic Monologue

8–14 September

Ulysses

Alfred, Lord Tennyson

It little profits that an idle king,
By this still hearth, among these barren crags,
Match'd with an aged wife, I mete and dole
Unequal laws unto a savage race,
That hoard, and sleep, and feed, and know not me.
I cannot rest from travel: I will drink
Life to the lees: All times I have enjoy'd
Greatly, have suffer'd greatly, both with those
That loved me, and alone, on shore, and when
Thro' scudding drifts the rainy Hyades
Vext the dim sea: I am become a name;
For always roaming with a hungry heart
Much have I seen and known; cities of men
And manners, climates, councils, governments,
Myself not least, but honour'd of them all;
And drunk delight of battle with my peers,
Far on the ringing plains of windy Troy.
I am a part of all that I have met;
Yet all experience is an arch wherethro'
Gleams that untravell'd world whose margin fades
For ever and forever when I move.
How dull it is to pause, to make an end,
To rust unburnish'd, not to shine in use!

As tho' to breathe were life! Life piled on life
Were all too little, and of one to me
Little remains: but every hour is saved
From that eternal silence, something more,
A bringer of new things; and vile it were
For some three suns to store and hoard myself,
And this gray spirit yearning in desire
To follow knowledge like a sinking star,
Beyond the utmost bound of human thought.

This is my son, mine own Telemachus,
To whom I leave the sceptre and the isle,—
Well-loved of me, discerning to fulfil
This labour, by slow prudence to make mild
A rugged people, and thro' soft degrees
Subdue them to the useful and the good.
Most blameless is he, centred in the sphere
Of common duties, decent not to fail
In offices of tenderness, and pay
Meet adoration to my household gods,
When I am gone. He works his work, I mine.

There lies the port; the vessel puffs her sail:
There gloom the dark, broad seas. My mariners,
Souls that have toil'd, and wrought, and thought with me—
That ever with a frolic welcome took
The thunder and the sunshine, and opposed
Free hearts, free foreheads—you and I are old;
Old age hath yet his honour and his toil;
Death closes all: but something ere the end,
Some work of noble note, may yet be done,
Not unbecoming men that strove with Gods.
The lights begin to twinkle from the rocks:

The long day wanes: the slow moon climbs: the deep
Moans round with many voices. Come, my friends,
'Tis not too late to seek a newer world.
Push off, and sitting well in order smite
The sounding furrows; for my purpose holds
To sail beyond the sunset, and the baths
Of all the western stars, until I die.
It may be that the gulfs will wash us down:
It may be we shall touch the Happy Isles,
And see the great Achilles, whom we knew.
Tho' much is taken, much abides; and tho'
We are not now that strength which in old days
Moved earth and heaven, that which we are, we are;
One equal temper of heroic hearts,
Made weak by time and fate, but strong in will
To strive, to seek, to find, and not to yield.

Week seven

The Dramatic Monologue

15–21 September

My Last Duchess

Robert Browning

Ferrara

That's my last Duchess painted on the wall,
Looking as if she were alive. I call
That piece a wonder, now; Fra Pandolf's hands
Worked busily a day, and there she stands.
Will't please you sit and look at her? I said
"Fra Pandolf" by design, for never read
Strangers like you that pictured countenance,
The depth and passion of its earnest glance,
But to myself they turned (since none puts by
The curtain I have drawn for you, but I)
And seemed as they would ask me, if they durst,
How such a glance came there; so, not the first
Are you to turn and ask thus. Sir, 'twas not
Her husband's presence only, called that spot
Of joy into the Duchess' cheek; perhaps
Fra Pandolf chanced to say, "Her mantle laps
Over my lady's wrist too much," or "Paint
Must never hope to reproduce the faint
Half-flush that dies along her throat." Such stuff
Was courtesy, she thought, and cause enough
For calling up that spot of joy. She had

A heart—how shall I say?— too soon made glad,
Too easily impressed; she liked whate'er
She looked on, and her looks went everywhere.
Sir, 'twas all one! My favour at her breast,
The dropping of the daylight in the West,
The bough of cherries some officious fool
Broke in the orchard for her, the white mule
She rode with round the terrace—all and each
Would draw from her alike the approving speech,
Or blush, at least. She thanked men—good! but thanked
Somehow—I know not how—as if she ranked
My gift of a nine-hundred-years-old name
With anybody's gift. Who'd stoop to blame
This sort of trifling? Even had you skill
In speech—which I have not—to make your will
Quite clear to such an one, and say, "Just this
Or that in you disgusts me; here you miss,
Or there exceed the mark"—and if she let
Herself be lessoned so, nor plainly set
Her wits to yours, forsooth, and made excuse—
E'en then would be some stooping; and I choose
Never to stoop. Oh, sir, she smiled, no doubt,
Whene'er I passed her; but who passed without
Much the same smile? This grew; I gave commands;
Then all smiles stopped together. There she stands
As if alive. Will't please you rise? We'll meet
The company below, then. I repeat,
The Count your master's known munificence
Is ample warrant that no just pretense
Of mine for dowry will be disallowed;
Though his fair daughter's self, as I avowed
At starting, is my object. Nay, we'll go

Together down, sir. Notice Neptune, though,
Taming a sea-horse, thought a rarity,
Which Claus of Innsbruck cast in bronze for me!

Week eight

The Short Story

22–28 September

The Verger

W. Somerset Maugham

There had been a christening that afternoon at St Peter's, Neville Square, and Albert Edward Foreman still wore his verger's gown. He kept his new one, its folds as full and stiff as though it were made not of alpaca but of perennial bronze, for funerals and weddings (St Peter's, Neville Square, was a church much favoured by the fashionable for these ceremonies) and now he wore only his second-best. He wore it with complacence, for it was the dignified symbol of his office, and without it (when he took it off to go home) he had the disconcerting sensation of being somewhat insufficiently clad. He took pains with it; he pressed it and ironed it himself. During the sixteen years he had been verger of this church he had had a succession of such gowns, but he had never been able to throw them away when they were worn out and the complete series, neatly wrapped up in brown paper, lay in the bottom drawers of the wardrobe in his bedroom.

The verger busied himself quietly, replacing the painted wooden cover on the marble font, taking away a chair that had been brought for an infirm old lady, and waited for the vicar to have finished in the vestry so that he could tidy up in there and go home. Presently he saw him walk across the chancel, genuflect in front of the high altar, and come down the aisle; but he still wore his cassock.

'What's he 'anging about for?' the verger said to himself. 'Don't 'e know I want my tea?'

The vicar had been but recently appointed, a red-faced energetic man in the early forties, and Albert Edward still regretted his predecessor, a clergyman of the old school who preached leisurely sermons in a silvery voice and dined out a great deal with his more aristocratic parishioners. He liked things in church to be just so, but he never fussed; he was not like this new man who wanted to have his finger in every pie. But Albert Edward was tolerant. St Peter's was in a very good neighbourhood and the parishioners were a very nice class of people. The new vicar had come from the East End and he couldn't be expected to fall in all at once with the discreet ways of his fashionable congregation.

'All this 'ustle,' said Albert Edward. 'But give 'im time, he'll learn.'

When the vicar had walked down the aisle so far that he could address the verger without raising his voice more than was becoming in a place of worship he stopped.

'Foreman, will you come into the vestry for a minute. I have something to say to you.' 'Very good, sir.'

The vicar waited for him to come up and they walked up the church together.

'A very nice christening, I thought, sir. Funny 'ow the baby stopped cryin' the moment you took him.'

'I've noticed they very often do,' said the vicar, with a little smile. 'After all I've had a good deal of practice with them.'

It was a source of subdued pride to him that he could nearly always quiet a whimpering infant by the manner in which he held it and he was not unconscious of the amused admiration with which mothers and nurses watched him settle the baby in the crook of his surpliced arm. The verger knew that it pleased him to be complimented on his talent. The vicar preceded Albert Edward into the vestry. Albert Edward was a trifle surprised to find the two churchwardens there. He had not seen them come in. They gave him pleasant nods.

'Good afternoon, my lord. Good afternoon, sir,' he said to one after the other.

They were elderly men, both of them, and they had been churchwardens almost as long as Albert Edward had been verger. They were sitting now at a handsome refectory table that the old vicar had brought many years before from Italy and the vicar sat down in the vacant chair between them. Albert Edward faced them, the table between him and them, and wondered with slight uneasiness what was the matter. He remembered still the occasion on which the organist had got into trouble and the bother they had all had to hush things up. In a church like St Peter's, Neville Square, they couldn't afford a scandal. On the vicar's red face was a look of resolute benignity, but the others bore an expression that was slightly troubled.

'He's been naggin' them, he 'as,' said the verger to himself. 'He's jockeyed them into doin' something, but they don't 'alf like it. That's what it is, you mark my words."

But his thoughts did not appear on Albert Edward's clean-cut and distinguished features. He stood in a respectful but not obsequious attitude. He had been in service before he was appointed to his ecclesiastical office, but only in very good houses, and his deportment was irreproachable. Starting as a pageboy in the household of a merchant prince, he had risen by due degrees from the position of fourth to first footman, for a year he had been single-handed butler to a widowed peeress, and, till the vacancy occurred at St Peter's, butler with two men under him in the house of a retired ambassador. He was tall, spare, grave, and dignified. He looked, if not like a duke, at least like an actor of the old school who specialized in dukes' parts. He had tact, firmness, and self-assurance. His character was unimpeachable. The vicar began briskly.

'Foreman, we've got something rather unpleasant to say to you. You've been here a great many years and I think his lordship and the general agree with me that you've fulfilled the duties of your office to the satisfaction of everybody concerned.'

The two churchwardens nodded.

'But a most extraordinary circumstance came to my knowledge the other day and I felt it my duty to impart it to the churchwardens. I discovered to my astonishment that you could neither read nor write.'

The verger's face betrayed no sign of embarrassment.

'The last vicar knew that, sir,' he replied. 'He said it didn't make no difference. He always said there was a great deal too much education in the world for 'is taste.'

'It's the most amazing thing I ever heard,' cried the general. 'Do you mean to say that you've been verger of this church for sixteen years and never learned to read or write?'

'I went into service when I was twelve, sir. The cook in the first place tried to teach me once, but I didn't seem to 'ave the knack for it, and then what with one thing and another I never seemed to'ave the time. I've never really found the want of it. I think a lot of these young fellows waste a rare lot of time readin' when they might be doin' something useful.'

'But don't you want to know the news?' said the other churchwarden. 'Don't you ever want to write a letter?'

'No, me lord, I seem to manage very well without. And of late years now they've all these pictures in the papers I get to know what's goin' on pretty well. Me wife's quite a scholar and if I want to write a letter she writes it for me. It's not as if I was a bettin' man.' The two churchwardens gave the vicar a troubled glance and then looked down at the table.

'Well, Foreman, I've talked the matter over with these gentlemen and they quite agree with me that the situation is impossible. At a church like St Peter's, Neville Square, we cannot have a verger who can neither read nor write.'

Albert Edward's thin, sallow face reddened and he moved uneasily on his feet, but he made no reply.

'Understand me, Foreman, I have no complaint to make against you. You do your work quite satisfactorily; I have the highest opinion both of your character and of your capacity; but we haven't the right to take

the risk of some accident that might happen owing to your lamentable ignorance. It's a matter of prudence as well as of principle.'

'But couldn't you learn, Foreman?' asked the general.

'No, sir, I'm afraid I couldn't, not now. You see, I'm not as young as I was and if I couldn't seem able to get the letters in me 'ead when I was a nipper I don't think there's much chance of it now.'

'We don't want to be harsh with you, Foreman,' said the vicar. 'But the churchwardens and I have quite made up our minds. We'll give you three months and if at the end of that time you cannot read and write I'm afraid you'll have to go.'

Albert Edward had never liked the new vicar. He'd said from the beginning that they'd made a mistake when they gave him St Peter's. He wasn't the type of man they wanted with a classy congregation like that. And now he straightened himself a little. He knew his value and he wasn't going to allow himself to be put upon. 'I'm very sorry, sir, I'm afraid it's no good. I'm too old a dog to learn new tricks. I've lived a good many years without knowin' 'ow to read and write, and without wishin' to praise myself, self praise is no recommendation, I don't mind sayin' I've done my duty in that state of life in which it 'as pleased a merciful providence to place me, and if I could learn now I don't know as I'd want to.'

'In that case, Foreman, I'm afraid you must go.'

'Yes, sir, I quite understand. I shall be 'appy to 'and in my resignation as soon as you've found somebody to take my place.'

But when Albert Edward with his usual politeness had closed the church door behind the vicar and the two churchwardens he could not sustain the air of unruffled dignity with which he had borne the blow inflicted upon him and his lips quivered. He walked slowly back to the vestry and hung up on its proper peg his verger's gown. He sighed as he thought of all the grand funerals and smart weddings it had seen. He tidied everything up, put on his coat, and hat in hand walked down the aisle. He locked the church door behind him. He strolled across the square, but deep in his sad thoughts he did not take the street that

led him home, where a nice strong cup of tea awaited him; he took the wrong turning. He walked slowly along. His heart was heavy. He did not know what he should do with himself. He did not fancy the notion of going back to domestic service; after being his own master for so many years, for the vicar and churchwardens could say what they liked, it was he that had run St Peter's, Neville Square, he could scarcely demean himself by accepting a situation. He had saved a tidy sum, but not enough to live on without doing something, and life seemed to cost more every year. He had never thought to be troubled with such questions. The vergers of St Peter's, like the popes of Rome, were there for life. He had often thought of the pleasant reference the vicar would make in his sermon at evensong the first Sunday after his death to the long and faithful service, and the exemplary character of their late verger, Albert Edward Foreman. He sighed deeply. Albert Edward was a non-smoker and a total abstainer, but with a certain latitude; that is to say he liked a glass of beer with his dinner and when he was tired he enjoyed a cigarette. It occurred to him now that one would comfort him and since he did not carry them he looked about him for a shop where he could buy a packet of Gold Flake. He did not at once see one and walked on a little. It was a long street, with all sorts of shops in it, but there was not a single one where you could buy cigarettes.

'That's strange,' said Albert Edward.

To make sure he walked right up the street again. No, there was no doubt about it. He stopped and looked reflectively up and down.

'I can't be the only man as walks along this street and wants a fag,' he said. 'I shouldn't wonder but what a fellow might do very well with a little shop here. Tobacco and sweets, you know.'

He gave a sudden start. 'That's an idea,' he said. 'Strange 'ow things come to you when you least expect it.'

He turned, walked home, and had his tea.

'You're very silent this afternoon, Albert,' his wife remarked. 'I'm thinkin',' he said.

He considered the matter from every point of view and next day he went along the street and by good luck found a little shop to let that looked as though it would exactly suit him. Twenty-four hours later he had taken it, and when a month after that he left St Peter's, Neville Square, for ever, Albert Edward Foreman set up in business as a tobacconist and newsagent. His wife said it was a dreadful come-down after being verger of St Peter's, but he answered that you had to move with the times, the church wasn't what it was, and 'enceforward he was going to render unto Caesar what was Caesar's. Albert Edward did very well. He did so well that in a year or so it struck him that he might take a second shop and put a manager in. He looked for another long street that hadn't got a tobacconist in it and when he found it, and a shop to let, took it and stocked it. This was a success too. Then it occurred to him that if he could run two he could run half a dozen, so he began walking about London, and whenever he found a long street that had no tobacconist and a shop to let he took it. In the course of ten years he had acquired no less than ten shops and he was making money hand over fist. He went round to all of them himself every Monday, collected the week's takings, and took them to the bank.

One morning when he was there paying in a bundle of notes and a heavy bag of silver the cashier told him that the manager would like to see him. He was shown into an office and the manager shook hands with him.

'Mr Foreman, I wanted to have a talk to you about the money you've got on deposit with us. D'you know exactly how much it is?'

'Not within a pound or two, sir; but I've got a pretty rough idea.'

'Apart from what you paid in this morning it's a little over thirty thousand pounds. That's a very large sum to have on deposit and I should have thought you'd do better to invest it.'

'I wouldn't want to take no risk, sir. I know it's safe in the bank.'

'You needn't have the least anxiety. We'll make you out a list of absolutely gilt-edged securities. They'll bring you in a better rate of interest than we can possibly afford to give you.'

A troubled look settled on Mr Foreman's distinguished face. 'I've never 'ad anything to do with stocks and shares and I'd 'ave to leave it all in your 'ands,' he said.

The manager smiled. 'We'll do everything. All you'll have to do next time you come in is just to sign the transfers.'

'I could do that all right,' said Albert uncertainly. 'But 'ow should I know what I was signin'?'

'I suppose you can read,' said the manager a trifle sharply.

Mr Foreman gave him a disarming smile.

'Well, sir, that's just it. I can't. I know it sounds funny-like, but there it is, I can't read or write, only me name, an' I only learnt to do that when I went into business.'

The manager was so surprised that he jumped up from his chair.

'That's the most extraordinary thing I ever heard.'

'You see, it's like this, sir, I never 'ad the opportunity until it was too late and then some'ow I wouldn't. I got obstinate-like.'

The manager stared at him as though he were a prehistoric monster.

'And do you mean to say that you've built up this important business and amassed a fortune of thirty thousand pounds without being able to read or write? Good God, man, what would you be now if you had been able to?'

'I can tell you that, sir,' said Mr Foreman, a little smile on his still aristocratic features. 'I'd be verger of St Peter's, Neville Square.'

Week nine

Biography

29 September–5 October

Stanley Finds Livingstone

Lawrence Wilson

ABOUT THE AUTHOR

David Livingstone was born in 1813 in Scotland to very religious parents. A Scottish missionary cum explorer, he was different from other missionaries and other explorers. He decided to explore the dark interiors of Africa and find out the source of the river Nile. He wanted to evangelize less and explore more and accepted the assignment from Royal Geographical Society in 1865. Though hampered by bouts of malaria and dysentery, he managed to find a number of water bodies. At one point there were rumours that he was dead as there was no sign of his whereabouts. In 1869, nearly four years after he was sent, New York Herald sent Stanley on an assignment to Ujiji near Lake Tanganyika to find David Livingstone.

ABOUT THE TEXT

This extract is from Lawrence Wilson's *Stanley Finds Livingstone*. It graphically describes the travails faced by Stanley in his attempt to find Livingstone. Stanley undertook the expedition after fully equipping himself with arms, ammunitions, bales of cloth, tents, medicines, money and coloured beads (native equivalent of money). There were five caravans in all and they had to pass through nearly 750 miles. Stanley faced every kind of problem including sickness, pillage and mutiny. At the end of all the traumatic experiences, Stanley found Dr. Livingstone.

Approaching Livingstone, Stanley spoke the famous words 'Dr. Livingstone, I presume.' Livingstone received him with kindness and Stanley's report of his meeting became one of the biggest journalistic scoops.

Late on an October night in 1869, James Gordon Bennett, Jr., son of the elderly proprietor of the *New York Herald*, was in his bedroom at the Grand Hotel, Paris, when there was a knock on the door and a short, frowning, ugly young man presented himself.

"Who are you?" asked Bennett.

"My name is Stanley."

"Ah, yes." This was the special correspondent whom Bennett had summoned from covering the civil war in Spain. "Where do you think Livingstone is?" he said, coming straight to the point.

"I really don't know, Sir."

"Do you think he is alive?"

"He may be and he may not be."

"Well I think he is alive and I am going to send you to find him."

So began one of the most challenging journalistic assignments ever issued. Livingstone, the famous medical missionary and explorer who had penetrated almost one-third of unknown Africa and whose career was followed eagerly by millions in England and the United States, was thought to be somewhere in the middle of the Dark Continent—if he was alive. He had gone to Africa for the third time in 1865, starting from Zanzibar towards the interior and for the last four years no white man had set eyes on him. Rumours came that he had been murdered, but were disproved by letters from him. Then absolute silence fell and for the last twelve months Livingstone's whereabouts, his state of health, his activities had caused anxious conjecture. Here Bennett had seen his chance for a scoop and in Stanley the man to make it.

"Do what you think best," he told him, "but find Livingstone," and added money was no object. If the expedition cost more than a thousand

pounds, then he must draw another thousand and when that was finished, another, and then another.

"But find Livingstone."

With these words ringing in his ears Stanley left Paris and however astute, Bennett could never have realized just how well he had chosen his man. Stanley had a strong American twang and called himself an American citizen, but he was not. He had been born in Denbigh, North Wales, in 1841, the illegitimate son of Elizabeth Parry, a butcher's daughter and John Rowlant, a farmer. Neither parent would have anything to do with him and at six the unwanted child had been dumped into the terror and loneliness of a workhouse run by a sadistic ex-miner. Years of ill-treatment ended when the boy struck back one day, left his tormentor unconscious and fled to relatives who gave him odd jobs till, aged seventeen, he sailed as a cabin boy from Liverpool to New Orleans.

In the States the youth was unofficially adopted by a kindly merchant, Henry Morton Stanley, who gave him fatherly affection and his name, but died soon after. Stanley fought for the Confederates in the American Civil War, served as a seaman in merchant ships and the federal navy, then was taken on by the *New York Herald* as special correspondent covering the British campaign in Abyssinia. Burning in him was an urge to prove himself by outstanding achievement and so he accepted by a hostile world, and the assignment to find Livingstone was just what he needed; a clear-cut task, a chance for heroism, the prospect of fame if he succeeded. That he knew nothing of the African jungle, nothing of how to handle natives, nothing—except what his imagination conjured—of the dangers he would meet merely added to the challenge.

In January, 1871, having covered meanwhile the opening of the Suez Canal and travelled for his paper as far as Karachi, he was facing his first difficulties in Zanzibar. As a point to aim for he chose Ujiji, a place on the eastern shore of Lake Tanganyika, where Livingstone had been last heard of. But that was nearly 750 miles from the coast and to get there a massive expedition would be needed. No money had come from Bennett

and Stanley had only eighty pounds in his pocket. But thanks to his zeal and powers of persuasion, he managed to borrow a large sum from the American consul, taking care to conceal the real object of his journey.

Within the short space of a month Stanley had organized his expedition. He decided to take supplies to last two years—arms, ammunition, clothing, tents, medicines, cooking utensils—food as much as could be carried and the native equivalent of money in the form of coloured beads, rolls of cloth and wire. The beads were a problem: most tribes would accept only certain shapes and colours. Black beads were valued in one area, useless in another. Egg-shaped ones were acceptable in Ujiji, only red in Unyamwezi. Taking what advice he could, Stanley spent eight thousand dollars on "currency", knowing that without it tribal chiefs would refuse to let him pass through their territory and the expedition might starve.

Finally, with everything packed into seventy-pound loads that could be carried on the head, the supplies weighed over six tons. As porters, two hundred Zanzibaris were engaged and two white men, both ex-merchant navy, to help supervise; a number of donkeys were bought. The whole party sailed for the mainland in March and at Bagamoyo on the Coast more porters had to be hired. This took time and before the expedition could start—split into five "caravans" with Stanley bringing up the rear—the rainy season with its mud and swollen rivers was almost on them.

But all were in high spirits as they set off, taking their women and cattle with them, the men singing at the top of their voices, the column guide waving the American flag and Stanley in white flannels and solar helmet cavorting on a bay horse to laughter and cheers from the locals.

There were various routes into the interior, but being in a hurry and "possessed by the power to achieve," Stanley chose to go due west and unwittingly took the hardest. The country was open savannah and under the rains soon turned to a bog. Temperatures were colossal, sometimes reaching 128 degrees, and there were myriads of insects which attacked men and animals and brought devastating fevers.

So the march was hard enough, but for Stanley there were graver problems. The natives were not interested in the expedition except to earn money or seize a chance to desert and steal the bales they were carrying. When the going became too tough they dropped away like flies and for the next eight months Stanley had to keep the column together by moral and often physical force.

Men who ran away, men who fell ill with smallpox, dysentery, elephantiasis or malaria, men who collapsed and died on the march, native chiefs who demanded extortionate payment before letting the column pass, savage tribes who waited to fall shrieking on the travellers and stripped them of all they possessed, starvation, thirst, exhaustion of body and mind—all these troubles lay in wait.

Meanwhile, ten miles from the start, the first of many marshy rivers was encountered where pack-animals had to be unloaded and led over a makeshift bridge of tree trunks and porters sank to their waists in slimy ooze. Then the column went climbing up to a plateau and from there followed a regular caravan route used by Arab traders, moving from village to village where food and water could be obtained. These places were mostly hotbeds of disease and soon Stanley's two horses died and many of the men were ill.

Stanley dosed them and did not hesitate to use a whip when he judged them well enough to move on. Then, rousing the column before dawn with a tattoo on a cooking pan, he led them, on foot himself this time, at a killing pace to their next bivouac. For several days the expedition trudged southwest and then west through an impressive town called Simbamwenni (recently identified as the modern Morogoro) towards an encampment on the far side where, for the first time of many, the leader went down with malaria. The site, used by generations of Arab traders and their porters, was filthy and Stanley, tossing with fever in his tent, was plagued by armies of ants and centipedes.

For two months Stanley passed his apprenticeship in African travel and by May the worst physical difficulties were over when the expedition

reached higher land beyond the Usagara mountains. There he joined an Arab convoy for safety, but their combined forces were soon attacked by hostile tribes, while Stanley again went down with fever. With his well-armed men he was not afraid of enemy spears, but endless haggling over tribute at tribal boundaries exasperated him and more than once his hot temper nearly led to disaster. But the worst trial of all was still to come. At Tabora, a township about 200 miles east of Lake Tanganyika, Stanley received devastating news; over all the country between him and his goal a full-scale war was in progress with an African chief named Mirambo, who had blocked the caravan route to Ujiji and was laying waste the region. Stanley lent his men to fight with the Arabs against him. Most of them were killed. Stanley collapsed with fever again. Then Mirambo attacked Tabora; Stanley prepared for a last-ditch defence—and was saved by Mirambo drawing off with his booty-laden warriors.

After three months in Tabora, Stanley set off again with fresh recruits, and to avoid the battle area took a wide detour to the south through unknown country which tripled the remaining distance to Ujiji. Several men succumbed to smallpox and fever; others deserted and capturing them, Stanley flogged them and chained them together. His iron will drove the party on, mastering even a mutiny when he was in danger of his life.

Then came a country rich in game. There was an orgy of hunting and eating, and though stricken with fever again, Stanley began to feel that he might, after all, reach Ujiji. But was Livingstone there? Days later at a village he heard a rumour from travellers that a white man was somewhere ahead of him.

The news was vague, but enough to make Stanley's heart beat faster. Because there was still danger from hostile tribes he plunged into uninhabited country, part thick forest, part marsh and ravine, where he sank up to his neck in deep holes and then marched on, a mud pie on two legs, thinking it indecent to take off his clothes. The natives no doubt had a good laugh, but they admired and feared him and followed him willingly,

now, even existing for some time on sweetened tea when there was an absence of game.

Weeks passed till, sixty miles short of Ujiji, an African caravan coming from the opposite direction reported that a white man with a grey beard had just arrived there. "Hurrah" wrote Stanley in his diary. "This is Livingstone. He must be Livingstone. He can be no other.... But we must now march quick, lest he hears that we are coming and runs away..."

Marching "quick", the column soon landed in more trouble. The self-styled "king" of the Waha tribe, whose territory had to be crossed, demanded a ruinous tribute which, rather than pit his men against an overwhelming horde, Stanley paid—only to find the next village on the route forewarned and the king's brother clamouring for equal payment.

But five more villages lay ahead where more rolls of cloth could have to be handed over and Stanley simply could not meet this new demand. If he refused, on the other hand, the savages would descend and pillage his column to the bone. The only alternative was flight—and in the darkness one night, guided by two deserted slaves, he and his men crept away and by forced marches over plains and hills escaped from the Waha country.

Then came picturesque valleys, wild fruit-trees and beautiful flowers. The men were in high spirits. Ujiji lay ahead, and from a mountain spur came the first glimpse of Lake Tanganyika. Stanley was overwhelmed. But Livingstone? Already with pounding heart Stanley had ordered a servant to lay out his new flannel suit, oil his boots, chalk his helmet and fit a new puggaree "that I may make as presentable an appearance as possible before the white man with the grey beard."

The "braves" strode away light-heartedly down the mountain-side towards the town and while still a mile away, Stanley ordered the column to close up, the American flag to be held aloft at the front, the Zanzibar flag at the rear and as was customary, repeated volleys to be fired to announce the arrival of the caravan.

The people of Ujiji rushed up to meet and welcome him. Suddenly Stanley heard a voice say, "Good morning, Sir" and turning saw a native with a gleaming row of white teeth.

"And who the mischief are you?"

"I am Susi, the servant of Dr. Livingstone."

Susi ran back to tell his master and the column moved towards Livingstone's house where a crowd was already collecting. A slim, grey-bearded figure came out. "I see the doctor, Sir" said Stanley's servant.

At this moment Stanley suddenly felt uncertain. The doctor was an educated man from the British Isles where Stanley had suffered so much. How would he receive the workhouse brat? Stanley had indeed performed miracles. He had blazed a trail, brought needed supplies hundreds of miles, and braved death many times. But still he could not be sure. "I did not know", he wrote later, how he would receive me; so I did what cowardice and false pride suggested—was the best thing—walked deliberately to him, took off my hat, and said: "Dr. Livingstone. I presume?"

But the doctor was kind, and grateful and did not even mind that Stanley represented the *New York Herald* and with him in the next few weeks Stanley came to know the meaning of veneration, while in his heart, fanned by Livingstone's great example, burst into full fame the love of African exploration which was never to leave him.

Week ten

The Ballad

6–12 October

The Ballad of Father Gilligan

William Butler Yeats

The old priest Peter Gilligan
Was weary night and day;
For half his flock were in their beds,
Or under green sods lay.

Once, while he nodded on a chair,
At the moth-hour of eve,
Another poor man sent for him,
And he began to grieve.

'I have no rest, nor joy, nor peace,
For people die and die';
And after cried he, 'God forgive!
My body spake, not I!'

He knelt, and leaning on the chair
He prayed and fell asleep;
And the moth-hour went from the fields,
And stars began to peep.

They slowly into millions grew,
And leaves shook in the wind;
And God covered the world with shade,
And whispered to mankind.

Upon the time of sparrow-chirp
When the moths came once more.
The old priest Peter Gilligan
Stood upright on the floor.

'Mavrone, mavrone! the man has died
While I slept on the chair';
He roused his horse out of its sleep,
And rode with little care.

He rode now as he never rode,
By rocky lane and fen;
The sick man's wife opened the door:
'Father! you come again!'

'And is the poor man dead?' he cried.
'He died an hour ago.'
The old priest Peter Gilligan
In grief swayed to and fro.
'When you were gone, he turned and died
As merry as a bird.'
The old priest Peter Gilligan
He knelt him at that word.

'He Who hath made the night of stars
For souls who tire and bleed,
Sent one of His great angels down
To help me in my need.

'He Who is wrapped in purple robes,
With planets in His care,
Had pity on the least of things
Asleep upon a chair.'

The Rime of the Ancient Mariner

Part I

Samuel Taylor Coleridge

It is an ancient Mariner,
And he stoppeth one of three.
'By thy long grey beard and glittering eye,
Now wherefore stopp'st thou me?

The Bridegroom's doors are opened wide,
And I am next of kin;
The guests are met, the feast is set:
May'st hear the merry din.'

He holds him with his skinny hand,
'There was a ship,' quoth he.
'Hold off! unhand me, grey-beard loon!'
Eftsoons his hand dropt he.

He holds him with his glittering eye—
The Wedding-Guest stood still,
And listens like a three years' child:
The Mariner hath his will.

The Wedding-Guest sat on a stone:
He cannot choose but hear;
And thus spake on that ancient man,

The bright-eyed Mariner.

'The ship was cheered, the harbour cleared,
Merrily did we drop
Below the kirk, below the hill,
Below the lighthouse top.

The Sun came up upon the left,
Out of the sea came he!
And he shone bright, and on the right
Went down into the sea.

Higher and higher every day,
Till over the mast at noon—'
The Wedding-Guest here beat his breast,
For he heard the loud bassoon.

The bride hath paced into the hall,
Red as a rose is she;
Nodding their heads before her goes
The merry minstrelsy.

The Wedding-Guest he beat his breast,
Yet he cannot choose but hear;
And thus spake on that ancient man,
The bright-eyed Mariner.

And now the STORM-BLAST came, and he
Was tyrannous and strong:
He struck with his o'ertaking wings,
And chased us south along.

With sloping masts and dipping prow,
As who pursued with yell and blow

Still treads the shadow of his foe,
And forward bends his head,
The ship drove fast, loud roared the blast,
And southward aye we fled.

And now there came both mist and snow,
And it grew wondrous cold:
And ice, mast-high, came floating by,
As green as emerald.

And through the drifts the snowy clifts
Did send a dismal sheen:
Nor shapes of men nor beasts we ken—
The ice was all between.

The ice was here, the ice was there,
The ice was all around:
It cracked and growled, and roared and howled,
Like noises in a swound!

At length did cross an Albatross,
Thorough the fog it came;
As if it had been a Christian soul,
We hailed it in God's name.

It ate the food it ne'er had eat,
And round and round it flew.
The ice did split with a thunder-fit;
The helmsman steered us through!
And a good south wind sprung up behind;
The Albatross did follow,
And every day, for food or play,
Came to the mariner's hollo!

In mist or cloud, on mast or shroud,
It perched for vespers nine;
Whiles all the night, through fog-smoke white,
Glimmered the white Moon-shine.'

'God save thee, ancient Mariner!
From the fiends, that plague thee thus!—
Why look'st thou so?'—With my cross-bow
I shot the ALBATROSS.

Week eleven

Idioms

13–19 October

English Idioms

Course handout

What are idioms? Among other things it is a group of words that give a figurative meaning.

It is an expression whose meaning cannot be traced to the individual words. They are also inflexible.

Match the following idioms with their meanings:

idioms	meanings
1. To have an axe to grind	a. to sidestep responsibility
2. An apple of discord	b. cramped airless condition
3. The acid test	c. in a state of elation
4. Black hole of Calcutta	d. Something that causes disagreement
5. On cloud nine	e. to have a secret motive
6. Bob is your uncle	f. the shortest distance between two places
7. To pass the buck	g. everything turns out well
8. To keep fingers crossed	h. a foolproof assessment
9. As the crow flies	i. to hope for a good outcome
10. The last straw	j. seemingly minor action that causes an unpleasant reaction